

THE BIG FIGHT Far left, PM Modi with Mahayuti leaders at a rally in Jalgaon in August; Rahul Gandhi with state Congress leaders in Amravati in April

taken a hit, the consensus being that he is to blame for the splits in the Sena and NCP. As the home minister, he also finds himself in the opposition crosshairs for the failing law-and-order situation after the recent assassination of NCP leader Baba Siddique and the 'police encounter' of Akshay Shinde, the accused in a case of sexual assault of minor girls in Badlapur near Mumbai. Shinde is also reportedly circumventing him, especially in postings of police officers. Fadnavis is now trying to redeem himself through a PR campaign, branding himself as the '*Deva bhau* (dear brother)' who ensured social development and worked for the masses.

What may also add to the BJP's woes is the Maratha disenchantment with the party, manifest in the Manoj Jarange-Patil-led agitation for reservations. The Marathas (about 12-16 per cent of the population) will have a major say in the Marathwada and western Maharashtra regions, which account for 104 seats. As a counter, the BJP has fallen back on its 'Madhav' formula to consolidate the backward Mali, Dhangar and Vanjari votes. But the lack of a singular and overarching OBC identity that transcends caste/religious lines makes it difficult for the backwards across 450 classes to mobilise to that extent. Apart from Marathwada (46 seats), the BJP is also on the back foot in its stronghold, Vidarbha (62 seats), due to factors like agrarian distress and rural discontent. Differences in the social coalitions stitched by the BJP are already cropping up. The Dhangars (shepherd community), the second-largest social group after the Maratha-Kunbi caste complex, are miffed at the BJP for reneging on their 2014 poll promise of giving them tribal status. The tribals are also upset at the BJP's bid to appease the Dhangars.

The Mahayuti has attempted to build a social coalition of smaller castes across categories like the Brahmins, Rajputs, Lingayats and Agaris, by approving welfare corporations for the economically weaker sections among them. It is also falling back on the politics of polarisation to galvanise its core Hindutva voters. A BJP leader says they expect this, coupled with news of the mobilisation of Muslim and minority voters for the MVA, to result in a "reverse mobilisation" of Hindus. A big plus for the BJP is that the Sangh parivar cadre have begun working for the party on the ground. The other surefire tropes, such as poll mascot PM Modi's presence, the lure of a 'double-engine' government, will also play their part in the campaign.

The Congress, despite its good showing in the Lok Sabha election, has also suffered a gradual erosion of its base. An exodus of the first- and second-rung leadership to the BJP, including ex-CM Ashok Chavan and former LoP Radhakrishna Vikhe-Patil, has significantly weakened it. But senior Congress leaders take heart from the fact that the party's core vote base—Muslims, tribals and Dalits—had closed ranks, as became evident in the Lok Sabha verdict. The results in Vidarbha also indicated that the farmers were returning to the party. "The agrarian ferment and anti-incumbency will hurt the BJP in Vidarbha," says a Congress functionary. With the BJP and Congress locked in a direct fight in the region, the latter is banking on local satraps rather than a single leader to help hike its tally. Party leaders claim they are gaining in the popular mandate and believe Rahul Gandhi, their main vote-catcher, could play a significant role too. The party had done well in the regions his Bharat Jodo yatras had passed through.

Despite the battle becoming increasingly bipolar, the two fronts also have to contend with smaller parties and alliances like the 'Parivartan Mahashakti', a third front formed by Maratha leaders and farmer groups led by ex-MP Sambhajiraje Chhatrapati, the titular crown prince of Kolhapur; the Vanchit Bahujan Aghadi (VBA) led by Babasaheb Ambedkar's grandson Prakash Ambedkar; Raj Thackeray's Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS); Asaduddin Owaisi's All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM) and Manoj Jarange-Patil's Maratha front. These formations may act as spoilers, just undo the best-laid plans of both the MVA and Mahayuti. All of which make this a maha cliff-hanger of a poll. ■

Advantage Congress

- **Core voters—the Muslims, Dalits and tribals—seem to have returned to Congress**
- **LS results in Vidarbha region suggest that agrarian community, too, is sympathetic**
- **LS results also lend psychological edge, the GOP having won 13 seats in Maharashtra , the most among all parties**
- **Rahul Gandhi proves effective vote-catcher. The party did well in the regions his two yatras passed through**